

Hey there! Current senior about to graduate with a major in CS. Overall I really like the CS department here, and as someone else said there are definitely some great students in the department, maybe more so than other schools. A few points I can try to address:

The curriculum certainly does have some theory-based classes like theory of computation and foundations of computer science. In my opinion, these can be really fun for anyone with a logic-loving mind. They might not be great experience if you're not looking to go to grad school for computer science, but they're still cool. One class that's more on the theoretical side, analysis of algorithms, is actually really helpful for nailing interviews because it's pretty common to be asked about runtime of programs and best algorithms/data structures for a specific task. Apart from that, there are some really good classes like software design and implementation that is exactly what you need to get your foot in the door at a software engineering internship. Lastly in terms of the curriculum, vassar has actually been overhauling how they approach CS for the past couple years, making good changes like teaching students python instead of a really old functional language, and allowing seniors to take more cool electives (robotics, bioinformatics, parallel programming, AI, etc.) over strictly required courses like operating systems and compilers (which would still be useful for some types of back-end jobs!). Basically, you'll probably get a better introduction to college level CS than I did, because I believe their finishing up those changes this summer.

For the most part, the professors are really great. Yes, there are a couple that might be nice to avoid if you have trouble sitting through a slow-paced class, but most of them are just wonderful. Smith, Gommerstadt, Waterman, Falcone, Gordon, Goodwin, they're all great, and what you're gonna get at vassar no matter what is professors who want to be as helpful as possible if you come to their office hours with questions.

Vassar is definitely a liberal arts school, but that means they give you a lot of freedom for classes you want to take. I've found myself being able to take as much cs as I want while still taking other classes I'm interested in, as the distribution requirements here are really flexible. In short, you can make the curriculum what you want. Want a STEM school? You can take up to 75% of your classes in the natural sciences, which are really well funded. Want a more balanced curriculum? A CS major is only about 1/3 of your required credits, so take some English classes or learn a language!

Vassar's alumni network is very well run and maintained. Though my class year didn't get it (covid), you will have a sophomore career connections event during winter break of sophomore year you can go to to meet a bunch of alums and learn more about networking and finding employment.

It's true that it can be a bit challenging to get into the classes you want, but the department is trying to deal with that and they're doing a somewhat decent job. What's great is that when you declare your major, you get access to preregister for classes before non-majors for upper level classes, which makes things a lot easier.

In terms of internships and jobs, it's hard to say because the job market in general is just a little rough right now. I know a bunch of people who are getting hired at great places right after they get their degree, and some people who are just gonna chill for a bit and reorganize. Finding internships can be hard (again, just in general), but Vassar's center for career education can be a good resource for that. Vassar also has a summer program called URSI that you can apply for, and oftentimes there'll be a couple CS professors who are hiring student researchers for their summer projects. I did it for a different department once and it was a great experience, though it can be tough to get a spot if there aren't many projects open. Apart from that, you can get hired during the year through work study as a research assistant for a prof or (more likely) as a coach/TA for a class you've already taken. This is a great resume builder and helps hone your communication skills, which is really important when interviewing for jobs/internships. In the end, a lot of it will come down to how motivated and prepared you are willing to be for the job hunt, because for CS jobs you'll usually need to send out a TON of applications, since that's what everyone is doing these days.

I hope any of that is helpful, and let me know if you have any more questions! I'm pursuing something related to my other major after I graduate so I may not be the perfect person to answer your questions, but happy to help if I can. :)